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Appeasing Populists' Constituents

IN CHAPTER 5, we demonstrated how IOs and their member states respond to populist attacks by offering to appease populist leaders. These strategies, including awarding states favorable loan terms, overlooking rules violations, or reforming institutional structures, aim to increase the benefits of IO participation for populist leaders. However, while effective in some respects, such measures often fail to address the significant ideological and domestic costs populists face when engaging with IOs.

As discussed in chapter 2, these costs arise on two fronts. Ideologically, populists often reject IOs as elite institutions that impose unwanted constraints. Domestically, positive engagement with IOs can clash with populists' anti-elite rhetoric, leading to perceptions of hypocrisy. Constituents may penalize leaders for these contradictions through protests or reduced political support, or at the ballot box. To mitigate these costs, IOs can go beyond appeasing leaders and address public opposition to IO engagement. The previous chapter explored one method of achieving this—operating out of public view. This chapter examines another strategy: improving public perceptions of IOs.

Public support is critical for IOs to maintain legitimacy and effectiveness (Milner and Tingley 2012; Bearce and Scott 2018; Zvogbo 2019; Brutger and Clark 2022), especially when faced with populist hostility. By increasing public approval, IOs can reduce the domestic pressure on populist leaders to oppose their operations, smoothing the way for such leaders to pursue open cooperation with IOs.